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Welcome to Your Cybersecurity Challenge!

Understanding Phishing

Before you begin this challenge, it is essential to distinguish between a **phishing tactic** (the psychological trick used) and a **technical indicator** (the verifiable, unforgeable fact).

- **Phishing Tactics (Social Engineering):** These are psychological tricks designed to manipulate you. They include creating a **sense of urgency** ("Act now!"), creating **fear** ("Your account is locked!"), or leveraging **authority** (impersonating a manager).
- **Phishing Indicators (Red Flags):** These are the verifiable signs that the message is malicious.
 - **Technical Indicators:** The most definitive flag. These include **incorrect sender email domains** (e.g., bank-support.co instead of bank.com) or **malicious link addresses** that point to a different website than the one listed (e.g., the visible text says bank.com, but the link points to scam.net).
 - **Content Indicators:** Less definitive, but highly suspicious. These include **poor grammar, misspellings, generic greetings, or unusual requests** (like buying gift cards).

Activity Directions:

For the following four questions, you will examine a suspicious email scenario. Your goal is to find the **most suspicious, definitive technical indicator** of a phishing attempt, even if other, less severe red flags are present.

Expected Process:

1. **Read the Email Scenario.**
2. **Evaluate the options, focusing on the technical element (domain, link).**
3. **Submit your answer for an instant grade and feedback.**

Scenario:

Phishing emails often contain multiple "red flags"—unusual signs that make them seem suspicious. Some red flags are subtle (like a generic greeting), while others are **definitive technical indicators** that prove the email is malicious (like a bad domain name). For each question below, your goal is to find the **most suspicious, definitive technical indicator** of a phishing attempt.

1. You receive this email, claiming to be from your bank. Which element is the most suspicious indicator that it's a phishing attempt? 1 / 1 point

Email Subject: ALERT! Unauthorized Login Detected on Your Bank Account

From: Bank Security! security@yourbank-support.co

Date: August 13, 2025

Body:

Dear Customer,

We have detected a suspicious login attempt on your account from an unrecognized device. For your safety, we have temporarily locked your account.

Click the link below to verify your identity and unlock your account.

UNLOCK MY ACCOUNT

Thank you,

Your Bank Security Team

- ☐ The link text "UNLOCK MY ACCOUNT"
- ☐ The greeting "Dear Customer"
- ☒ The sender's email address "security@yourbank-support.co"
- ☐ The phrase "temporarily locked your account"

Correct
A legitimate bank's email address would end in their official domain (e.g., yourbank.com), not a suspicious, similar-looking domain like "yourbank-support.co". This is a definitive technical indicator of a phishing attempt.

2. You get an email about a "Free Phone Upgrade" from your mobile carrier. The email contains several spelling and grammar errors. Which of the following best describes the **red flag** indicating this is a phishing attempt? 1 / 1 point

Email Subject: Exciting News! Your Free Upgrade To a New Phone!

From: Cellular Service! no-reply@cellularservice.pro

Date: August 13, 2025

Body:

Congratulations, valued customer! You have been chosen for a free upgrade to our new line of phones. To receive your new phone, just fill out the form by clicking the link below: CLAIM YOUR UPGRADE NOW (<http://freephone-upgrade.com>)

- ☒ A generic greeting like "valued customer"
- ☐ Types, misspellings, and poor grammar
- ☐ Asking you to click a link to claim your reward
- ☐ A sense of urgency (hurry to get your new phone!)

Correct
Phishers often make grammatical and spelling errors because they are not native English speakers, are using translation software, or are simply not careful. These errors are a classic red flag that a message is not from a professional, legitimate company.

3. You receive an email from a coworker asking for help. The email seems odd. What is the most likely phishing tactic being used here? 1 / 1 point

Email Subject: Need your help with a quick payment

From: "Your Manager" <manager.name@gmail.com>

Date: August 13, 2025

Body:

Hi team,

I'm in a meeting right now and I urgently need you to buy some gift cards for a client. Could you please send the details to me as soon as you can? I'll reimburse you later.

Thanks,

Manager Name

- ☐ The sender's name is "Your Manager"
- ☐ The email is too short and informal
- ☐ The subject line saying "need your help"
- ☐ The request for a quick, unusual payment with gift cards.

Correct
Phishers often impersonate a manager or executive to create an urgent and unusual request that bypasses normal company procedures. Requesting gift cards is a common tactic, as they are a form of payment that is difficult to trace.

4. You receive a security alert from a social media site. You hover your mouse over the "Verify Your Account" link. Which of these link addresses is a definitive sign of a phishing attempt? 1 / 1 point

Email Subject: Security Alert: We detected an unusual login

From: "Social Media" <verify@socialmedia.com>

Date: August 13, 2025

Body:

Hi Sarah, Someone has just logged in to your account from a new location. To secure your account, please click the link below immediately: [Verify Your Account]

- ☒ <http://login-security.net/socialmedia/verify>
- ☐ https://socialmedia.com/alerts/login_alerts
- ☐ <http://socialmedia.com/account/verify>
- ☐ <https://social-media.com/login>

Correct
A legitimate link from a company like "socialmedia.com" will almost always keep the company's domain name first in the URL (e.g., socialmedia.com/...). This link, however, points to an entirely different domain, "login-security.net", which is a clear and definitive sign of a phishing attempt.